LECTURE 10: NONVERBAL COMMUNICATION SKILLS

Introduction

Hello , and welcome to this week's lecture on non-verbal communication skills. In the previous lectures so far we have been discussing communication in general and focused mostly on Verbal Communication. In this lecture, we are going to shift our focus to Non-Verbal Communication.

As you may have noticed in your daily communication, much of the meaning we derive from communication, comes from non-verbal cues. In other words, while we tend to focus on what we say, it is the non-verbal communication that proves to be significant in conveying our message and forming judgments about others. Often a person says one thing but communicates something totally different through vocal intonation and body language.

These mixed signals can force the receiver to choose between the verbal and non-verbal parts of the message. Most often, the receiver chooses the non-verbal aspects.

To illustrate this, think about how vocal, facial and bodily behavior can change the meaning of the following statement, spoken to a student completing their first month of placement.

'Overall, things seem to be OK'. The same words can convey praise, uncertainty, annoyance, disappointment, sarcasm or indifference, depending on the accompanying non-verbal cues.

Or picture this: you visit a friend who is hospitalized and you greet them through this question; *How are you?* And they respond as "*fine*". Clearly you can see that the person is in pain from their sitting position to expression on the face but they say fine. In this case you have to choose the non-verbal clues to understand their response.

It is worthwhile pointing out this early that nonverbal communication is a challenging and the most significant component of communication.

Expected outcome:

After Completing this topic students should be able to:

- Define nonverbal communication.
- Compare and contrast verbal communication and nonverbal communication.
- Discuss the principles of nonverbal communication.
- Provide examples of the functions of nonverbal communication.
- effectually read body language cues from people and respond to them appropriately.

The meaning and nature of non-verbal communication

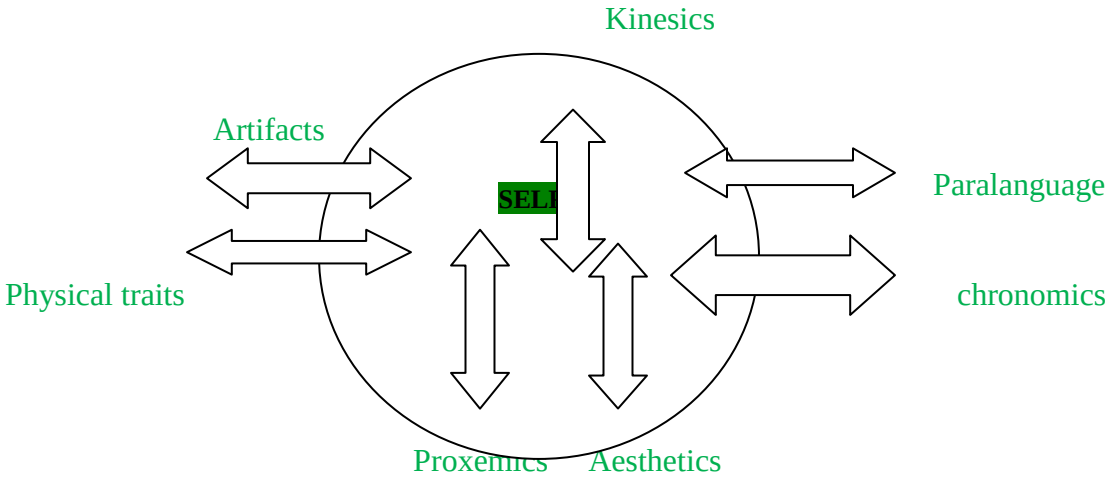
What is Non Verbal Communication?

Simply put, non-verbal Communication refers to the type of communication that involves neither written nor spoken words but occurs without the use of words.

- Non-verbal communication occurs without using any oral or written word.
- Instead of written or oral words, it relies on various non-verbal cues like physical movements, tasks, colors, signs, symbols, signals charts, etc. to express feelings, attitudes or information.
- Although no word is used in non-verbal communication, it can effectively communicate many human feelings more accurately than verbal methods of communication.

Many times, we tend to convey many of our feelings by smiling, patting, frowning, shouting or other such wordless clues. At other times, we also lace our words with different tones, gestures and facial expressions, to give a deeper meaning to our words.

Nonverbal messages, like other forms of communication, are conveyed through channels.



Due to the prevalence of nonverbal communication and its significant impact on organizational behavior (including, but not limited to, perceptions of others, hiring decisions, work attitudes, and turnover), it is important that managers become aware of the sources of nonverbal communication.

Nonverbal communication tends to do the work of communicating emotions more than verbal, we may rely more on nonverbal signals in situations where verbal and nonverbal messages conflict and in situations where emotional or relational communication is taking place. Nonverbal communication is primarily biologically based while verbal communication is primarily culturally biased.

CHARACTERISTICS OF NON-VERBAL COMMUNICATION

The following are the key characteristics of non-verbal communication:

1) Nonverbal communication may be intentional or unintentional, since often when people communicate nonverbally, they are unaware of it.
2) Nonverbal communication is primary, because it takes precedence over verbal communication.
3) Nonverbal communication is often ambiguous, since a nonverbal behaviour may have different meanings depending on the user's personality, family influences, and culture.
4) Nonverbal communication is continuous, because one is constantly communicating through nonverbal behaviours.
5) Nonverbal communication is multi-channelled, since we use a variety of cues to make an interpretation.

Principles of Nonverbal Communication

- **Nonverbal Communication Is More Involuntary than Verbal**-although most nonverbal communication isn't completely involuntary, it is more below our consciousness than verbal communication and therefore more difficult to control.

- **Ambiguous**-As with verbal communication, most of our nonverbal signals can be linked to multiple meanings, but unlike words, many nonverbal signals do not have any one specific meaning.
- **More Credible**-Although we can rely on verbal communication to fill in the blanks sometimes left by nonverbal expressions, we often put more trust into what people do over what they say. This is especially true in times of stress or danger when our behaviors become more instinctual.

Types of Nonverbal Communication

Kinesics

This is the study of communication through body movements such as gestures, gait, and walk, facial expressions of our faces and eyes, and the way we combine these variables to open or close channels of communication. Pearson J. and Nelson P. in *An Introduction to Human Communication*, state that 'the study of posture, movement, gestures, and facial expression is called **kinesics**, a word derived from the Greek word *kinesis,* meaning movement.' I shall now focus on these in details

1) Emblems –are nonverbal acts that have a direct verbal translation. Using thumbs and index finger for example, to form a circle, with the other three fingers outstretched, is a signal meaning "everything is all right"

2) Affect –are facial configurations that show emotions and feelings such as sadness or happiness. Pouting, winking, and raising eyelids or eye brows. This can become evident by watching people's behavior when their favorite team wins a game, and watching men make threatening moves when they are very upset with each other but don't dare fight openly.

3) Illustrators –these nonverbal cues tend to be more universal than many others. Nodding one's head when you say yes, shaking your head when you say no, stroking your stomach when you say you are hungry all tend to reinforce verbal messages.

4) Regulators –are nonverbal moves that control the flow or pace of communication. Examples of these may include shifting, moving away when you want the conversation to

stop, looking at the floor or looking away when you are disinterested, or yawning and looking at your watch when you are bored.

5) Adaptors –are movements that we might fully perform in private, but only partially in public. They include such acts as restless movements of hands and feet, tapping fingers, scratching our noses in public but not scratching everywhere it itches.

6) Walk and stance – the way a person walks says a lot about that person. It gives clues about his or her status, mood, ethnic and cultural affiliation, and self-perception. Detectives and airline security personnel are trained to pick out suspicious people by the way they walk, and blind people can identify others by the sound of their footsteps. Some people walk with confidence-head high, shoulders back, jaw set, and assurance in every movement.

7) Face and eyes –'The face is probably the most expressive part of our bodies and one of the more important focal points for nonverbal cues.' (Stewart and Logan 1993.)Frowns and pupils dilating or contracting reveal a lot about a person. When pupils dilate, the person may be said to be friendly, inviting and approachable, whereas when someone's pupils contract, they are said to be mean, cold and no nonsense by nature.

Paralanguage

This can also be referred to as the vocal sounds. All the vocal effects we make to accompany words, such as tone of voice, except the actual words spoken. Vocal quality communicate nonverbally to the listening ear. Voice features include;

- The pace-rate at which we speak
- The pitch-such as soprano or bass
- The volume-power of one's voice
- Pause- stopping and resting before continuing with speech

These are sometimes referred to as vocal cues

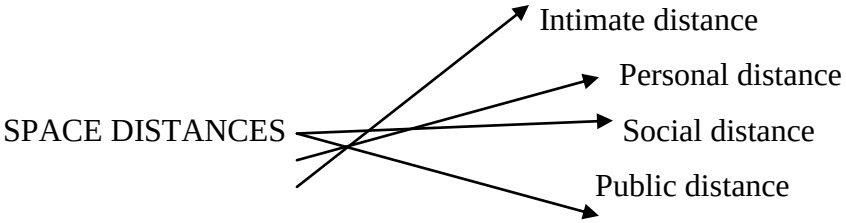
Application

We can use vocal cues to tell the sex, age, and stance of a speaker, the emotions, feelings etc of a speaker. Research findings indicate that the voice also may be important in some aspects of persuasion.

Proxemics

This is also referred to as space. The space around the speakers; how they use their territory. According to Edward Hall, every person is surrounded by *a psychological bubble of space*. This bubble can contract or expand depending on what she is talking about, emotional state and cultural background.

It is divided into 4 pace distances



1) ***Intimate distance*** is estimated at 0-18 inches, reminiscent during sexual contact, kissing, caressing, protecting and comforting among others. It defines a close relationship. When forced into intimate distance with strangers-as on an elevator, we tend to use other nonverbal cues to reestablish our separateness. So we avoid eye contact, fold our arms, or hold a briefcase or purse in front of our body.

2) ***Personal distance*** is defined as a 4-foot bubble. This is the distance preferred by most conversation partners in a public setting. Touch is still possible, but it is limited to brief pats of emphasis and reassurance.

3) ***Social distance*** is represented by 4-12 foot zone. This is commonly used during business transactions or social exchanges for example, by a boss to his secretary, teacher to his pupil.

4) ***Public distance*** represented by 12 feet to more than 25 feet. For example, facilitators in lecture rooms, speakers at public gatherings, churches, mosques, and in courtrooms.

Chronemics

It is also referred to as time. This is the way that people handle and structure their time. In most western societies, precise time is of great significance, hence considered punctual, and punctuality is part of good manners. At places of work, punctuality is used as a measure of efficiency or effectiveness. Tardiness results in several negative effects such as firing, reprimand, and lack of promotions. Within cultures that value promptness, one of the questions often raised about time centers on the individual who is constantly late. What does habitual tardiness reveal about the person?

Aesthetics

It also encompasses the use of music and color. The communication of a message or mood through colour or music is called aesthetics. For example, strolling through a supermarket, the music is slow and comfortable; the owner wants you to move slowly through the store, seeing everything there is to buy. Music has a therapeutic effect and depending on the kind of music played at specific events, the communication may be deemed effective or not.

Colour has a significant effect on people. For example, patients at hospitals, prisoners, and children. Some colours can make a person look sick or powerful depending on the individual's skin tone and hair colour.

Physical Characteristics

This is the general attractiveness, body and breathe odors, and height are all non-verbal communication signs.

- Attractiveness; we often are drawn to or repulsed by people according to how they appear physically.
- Height; there is a common discrimination against short men even in career settings. Everything is usually pegged on their heights.
- Smell; our senses can also affect communication. Certain body odors are considered offensive and people may make discussions about others without recognizing that they are based on odors.

Artifacts

Artifacts are ornaments or adornments we display that hold communicative potential, including the clothing that a person wears, make-up, eye glasses, hairstyles, cosmetics and

jewelry among others. These carry distinct messages. Dress conservatively but appropriately for your age and social standing.

Functions of Nonverbal Communication

- **Conveys Meaning**-Nonverbal communication conveys meaning by reinforcing, substituting for, or contradicting verbal communication.
- **Influences Others**-Nonverbal communication can be used to influence people in a variety of ways, but the most common way is through deception. Deception is typically thought of as the intentional act of altering information to influence another person, which means that it extends beyond lying to include concealing, omitting, or exaggerating information.
- **Expresses Our Identities**-Nonverbal communication expresses who we are. Our identities (the groups to which we belong, our cultures, our hobbies and interests, etc.) are conveyed nonverbally through the way we set up our living and working spaces, the clothes we wear, the way we carry ourselves, and the accents and tones of our voices.
- **Nonverbal communication affects relationships**- as it is a primary means through which we communicate emotions, establish social bonds, and engage in relational maintenance.

Roles of non-verbal codes in verbal communication

- **Repetition**: It repeats and often strengthens the message you're making verbally.
- **Contradiction:** It can contradict the message you're trying to convey, thus indicating to your listener that you may not be telling the truth.
- **Substitution:** It can substitute for a verbal message. For example, your facial expression often conveys a far more vivid message than words ever can.
- **Complementing:** It may add to or complement your verbal message. As a boss, if you pat an employee on the back in addition to giving praise, it can increase the impact of your message.
- **Accenting:** It may accent or underline a verbal message. Pounding the table, for example, can underline the importance of your message.

Problems of Nonverbal Communication

Nonverbal communication is responsible for much of the misunderstanding that occurs during communication. Just as people have difficulty interpreting verbal symbols, so do they struggle to interpret nonverbal codes. The ambiguity of nonverbal communication occurs for two reasons: People use the same code to communicate a variety of meanings, and they use a variety of codes to communicate the same meaning.

One Code Communicates a Variety of Meanings

The ambiguity of nonverbal codes occurs in part because one code may communicate several different meanings. For example, the nonverbal code of raising your right hand may mean that you are taking an oath, you are demonstrating for a cause, you are indicating to an instructor that you would like to answer a question, a physician is examining your right side, or you want a taxi to stop for you. Also consider how you may stand close to someone because of a feeling of affection, because the room is crowded, or because you have diffi culty hearing.

Although people in laboratory experiments have demonstrated some success in decoding nonverbal behavior accurately (Horgan & Smith, 2006), in actual situations receivers of nonverbal cues can only guess about the meaning of the cue (Motley & Camden, 1988). Several lay authors have been successful in selling books suggesting that observers can learn to easily and accurately distinguish meaning from specific nonverbal cues. Unfortunately, these authors have not been able to demonstrate any significant improvement among their readers. Single cues can be interpreted in multiple ways.

Emoticons are important tools when you are trying to convey your feelings to another person electronically. Without vocal inflections, facial expression, and bodily movement, your emotions are difficult to interpret. Emoticons can be helpful in avoiding misunderstanding. No absolute, standard definitions exist for individual emoticons, but many people have common understandings for a variety of these symbols. Generally, emoticons are made to resemble a face. Four examples are provided here. You can easily fi nd additional examples online by using a search engine and the key word *emoticons*.

:-) Happiness or humor

:-I Indifference

:-Q Confusion

:-O Surprise

A Variety of Codes Communicate the Same Meaning

Nonverbal communication is not a science: Any number of codes may be used to communicate the same meaning. One example is the many nonverbal ways by which adults communicate love or affection. You may sit or stand more closely to someone you love. You might speak more softly, use a certain vocal intonation, or alter how quickly you speak when you communicate with someone with whom you are affectionate. Or perhaps you choose to dress differently when you are going to be in the company of someone you love.

Cultural differences are especially relevant when we consider that multiple cues may be used to express a similar message. How do you show respect to a speaker in a public-speaking situation? In some cultures respect is shown by listeners when they avert their eyes; in other cultures listeners show respect and attention by looking directly at the speaker. You may believe that showing your emotions is an important first step in resolving conflict, whereas a classmate may feel that emotional responses interfere with conflict resolution.